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The Mapping of India

As we saw in Chapter 3, geographical awareness jumped sharply between the Vedic Age and the Iron Age. The epics clearly show knowledge of the far corners of the subcontinent. They certainly had a fairly detailed knowledge of the terrain by the time of the Mauryan empire. But, did ancient Indians try to map their country? Over centuries of maritime trade, they would have come to know quite a lot about the geography of the Indian Ocean rim, even as far as the Chinese coast in the west and of the Red Sea in the east. At the same time, they were also quite used to diagrammatic representation of ideas, including architectural plans. Thanks to Aryabhatta, by the time of the Guptas, Indians were aware that the world was spherical and even had a fairly accurate estimate of its circumference. All the ingredients of cartography were there—one would have expected the Indians to pull together this knowledge to systematically map their country and the surrounding oceans. Similarly, one would expect that there would be maritime manuals equivalent to the Greek *Periplus* to help merchants and seamen.

Yet, there is nothing to prove that ancient Indians ever attempted to map their country or systematically write down geographical knowledge. A seaman's manual written in the Kutchhi dialect of Gujarat has been found, but it exists as a relatively modern copy and nothing is known of its history.[1] Of maps there are none. Of course, it is entirely possible that such things existed but have been lost. What survives is a cosmological scheme